raise expectations of great progress at the meeting in Geneva.

George Shultz said it would be a success if the only thing that came out of it was an agreement to hold another summit. As far as I was concerned, I wanted to size up Gorbachev and let him know I was serious about reducing the nuclear threat. “Let’s paint with a broad brush and not give the press specifics as to our agenda,” I said.

As this was going on, Gorbachev and I continued our correspondence, much of it repetitious as both of us let the other side know where we stood.

This is a portion of one letter I received from Gorbachev in September 1985 that summarized the Soviet view of the United States before the meeting in Geneva:

Dear Mr. President:

> I would like to communicate some thoughts and considerations and continue the correspondence between us, specifically with the view to our forthcoming personal meeting. I assume that both of us take this meeting very seriously and are thoroughly preparing for it. The range of problems which we are to discuss has been fairly clearly delineated. They are all very important.
>
> Of course the differences between our two countries are not minor and our approaches to many fundamental issues are different. All this is true, but at the same time, the reality is such that our nations have to coexist whether we like each other or not. If things ever come to a military confrontation, it would be catastrophic for our countries and for the world as a whole. Judging by what you have said, Mr. President, you also regard a military conflict between the USSR and USA as inadmissible.